It wasn't just his friends, or the ability to do as he pleased, that Akbar was losing as he grew in stature and age; he would soon experience the most difficult loss of all – that of his children.

So much is written about Akbar's relationship with his sons and grandsons, particularly his heir Salim, that it is easy to forget the emperor had daughters and granddaughters, too. And he loved them deeply.

Two of Akbar's daughters died in infancy; and both times, writes Abul Fazl, their father's grief exceeded 'the mould of description'. Akbar, in sorrow, 'withdrew his heart from everything'. When, in December 1584, Akbar had a daughter who survived, Abul Fazl hails her as 'a night-gleaming jewel of fortune'. Salim, in his wonderful memoir, the *Jahangirnama*, puts it in less lofty terms. His younger sister, Aram Banu, was Akbar's '*ladli*,' his darling, and 'greatly inclined to volatility and sharpness'. She was spoilt silly, that is. 'My father loved her so much,' writes Salim, 'that he politely tolerated her acts of rudeness, and in his blessed sight . . . she did not seem so bad. He often said to me, "Baba, for my sake, after I'm gone, treat this sister of yours . . . as I do. Tolerate her coquettishness and overlook her rudeness and impudence."'[40]

For Salim's own daughters, too, the emperor had a special fondness. His first grandchild was a girl born to Man Bai – Salim's first wife and daughter of Bhagwant Das. Akbar was thrilled, writes Abul Fazl; he held a grand party in Hamida's house, with 'gifts, and . . . largesse' – even though such celebrations were 'contrary to the usage of contemporaries'. Three years later, in 1589, Salim had another daughter and Akbar another celebration – once again, 'contrary to the custom of contemporaries'.

Abul Fazl does not clarify what was unusual about celebrating a child's birth – in fact, a girl's birth – but it isn't hard to guess. Sons, of course, were – and remain – valued across cultures; Akbar himself had prayed for an heir. But valuing sons is not quite the same as scorning daughters – 'The result of karma' as the Jain poet Banarasidas describes his younger sister.[41] Akbar's own feelings about women were quite different from the notions he encountered in Hindustan, most intimately with his new Rajput allies and kin – and the two ways of seeing were often intermingled, often uncomfortably, in the emperor's mind.

It was with a bemused mix of wonderment and horror, for example, that